



# Safe Crewing for Maritime SAR Operations Guidance - GU1007

**Guidance owner**

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1.8

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Lifesaving Operations

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**Applicability**

All lifeboat operations.

**Background of Guidance**

To set out the safe crewing numbers and roles required to operate RNLI SAR assets.

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**Guidance**

The aim of this guidance is to ensure that all search and rescue (SAR) assets are operated with the right number of suitably competent crew to safely operate the asset. This applies for all service and exercise launches, passages and boat movements.

This guidance states the requirements of safe crewing including the:

- minimum and maximum crew numbers required
- minimum role types required
- selection of crew for service launches.

The RCAMS crew availability tool should be used to monitor crewing levels so the launch authority can make an informed decision on availability of assets. In cases where it is known that it will not be possible to crew a SAR asset that meets the requirements set out in this guidance, the local station management should report being 'off service' due to lack of available crew.

Where this is a regular occurrence, this should be recorded on the Line 1 Assurance report and discussed with the area operations manager (AOM). The procedure [changing a lifesaving asset service status procedure - PR1016](#) must be followed, including when needing to place the asset on 'delayed launch'.

Any requirement to operate outside of the guidance requires a concession in advance. This concession can only be granted by the Chief Operating Officer and Director of Regions or the Head of Lifeboats.

## Crewing numbers required for lifeboat operations

The table below lists the minimum and maximum number of crew to safely operate each class of SAR asset.

| SAR asset                           | Minimum crewing level on service and exercise | Maximum crewing level on service, exercise and passage | Minimum crewing level on passage |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Severn<br>Tamar<br>Trent            | 5                                             | 7                                                      | 4                                |
| Shannon                             | 5                                             | 6                                                      | 4                                |
| B class<br>E class                  | 3                                             | 4                                                      | 2 (3 in darkness)                |
| D class<br>Hovercraft               | 3                                             | 4                                                      | 3                                |
| A class (lifeboat use) <sup>1</sup> | 2                                             | 3                                                      | 2                                |
| RWC (lifeboat use) <sup>1</sup>     | 2                                             | 2                                                      | 2                                |
| Daughter craft (all types)          | 2                                             | 2                                                      | N/A                              |

<sup>1</sup> This asset can only be used as a SAR asset where approval has been given by the Chief Operating Officer and Director of Regions and there is an agreed LOP in place.

### ALB only – Additional crew on service

In exceptional circumstances the maximum crew stated above may be increased for service launches. Any additional persons taken aboard must comply with the Lifeboat Carriage Capacity as set out in Appendix 2 of the [Non-operational personnel on RNLI lifeboats policy](#).

Prior to any decision to take additional crew, a dynamic risk assessment must be conducted and agreed with the launch authority. In making the assessment to carry additional crew, the following should be amongst the points considered:

- Additional crew must be securely seated when the lifeboat is in transit.
- The lifeboat's speed must be suitably adjusted for the weather and sea conditions, especially where crew may not be in shock-mitigated seating.

### ALB only – Additional crew on exercise, passage or when launched for assurance activity

All weather lifeboats are permitted to carry up to two extra operational crew when on exercise if the planned activities support it. Where additional crew are taken, the lifeboat's speed must be suitably adjusted for the weather and sea conditions, especially where crew may not be in shock-mitigated seating.

Consideration must be given to returning the additional crew to a point of safety should a tasking be received. Any additional persons taken aboard must comply with the Lifeboat Carriage Capacity as set out in Appendix 2 of the [Non-operational personnel on RNLI lifeboats policy](#).



Minimum role types required for lifeboat operations

To achieve safe crewing levels each SAR asset must have a **minimum complement of roles** on board. The table below lists the minimum number of crew, **in each role**, required for each class of SAR asset. Roles below in **bold** must be crewed by fully competent and current individuals, and the crew fulfilling each role must be identified prior to launching.

The crew member in command must remain onboard at all times when the SAR asset is in operation, other than in an abandon ship scenario. Wherever possible, ALB coxswains should not be operating as both coxswain and mechanic while afloat, and ALB, B class and E class assets should have a navigator on board.

| ALB                            | ALB                            | B class                       | E class<br>B class (Thames)         | D class                       | Hovercraft                    | A class<br>Boarding<br>boat (SAR) |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| 1 coxswain                     | 1 coxswain/<br>mechanic        | 1 helm                        | 1 commander or<br>helm <sup>2</sup> | 1 helm                        | 1 commander                   | 1 helm                            |
| 1 mechanic                     | 1 navigator                    |                               | 1 navigator                         |                               | 1 pilot                       |                                   |
| 1 Tier 2<br>crew<br>member     | 1 Tier 2<br>crew<br>member     | 1 Tier 2<br>crew<br>member    |                                     | 1 Tier 2<br>crew<br>member    |                               |                                   |
| 2 crew<br>members <sup>1</sup> | 2 crew<br>members <sup>1</sup> | 1 crew<br>member <sup>1</sup> | 1 crew member <sup>1</sup>          | 1 crew<br>member <sup>1</sup> | 1 crew<br>member <sup>1</sup> | 1 crew<br>member <sup>1</sup>     |

<sup>1</sup> Must be 'Safe to go afloat' or above for exercise, and 'Safe to go on a service' or above for service.  
<sup>2</sup> A helm will require authorisation to launch from a competent launch authority.

On exercise, the requirement to carry a Tier 2 crew member on ALBs & ILBs, a navigator for Thames E and B class stations, and inshore rescue hovercraft (IRH) pilots for IRH can be relaxed with LA discretion **if alternative mitigations are implemented**.

- These mitigations include, but are not limited to:
- Lifeboat is to be declared 'non-SAR capable'.
  - Consider crew capability in relation to weather conditions and launch and recovery.
  - PIM reporting is still conducted in line with [Radio Procedure – PR1052](#).
  - A robust plan to embark/disembark crew if a tasking request is received.

This will be reviewed again in 12 months to understand its efficacy.

The scheme of complement at a station should be managed to support meeting these requirements. For some classes of SAR asset, changes have been made to the minimum complement of roles required on board. In order to give time for stations to achieve this, a phased approach has been taken to allow for the scheme of complement to be built where required.

**From 1 January 2027**, a dedicated navigator will be required on ALBs and B class lifeboats at all times. This will replace the Tier 2 crew requirement.

Selection of crew for service launches

Before the lifeboat is launched on service the person in command must ensure that the required minimum complement of competent crew (numbers and roles as set out above) is on board. Only enrolled lifeboat crew members and operationally competent/qualified RNLI employees count towards the minimum crewing levels.

If a sufficient **number** of competent and current crew are not present for a service request, the launching authority and coxswain/helm/commander **must** conduct a dynamic risk assessment to determine the best course of action and urgency of the situation with respect to risk to life.

Options to consider might include declining the request to launch or delaying the launch until suitable crew are available. If the requirements of this guidance cannot be met, a detailed account **must** be made in the service return.

Without exception, the **roles** set out in bold in the 'Minimum role types required' section above **must** be filled by competent crew who meet the requirements of the [Lifeboat Training Standards](#) to carry out the role. The dynamic risk assessment conducted above cannot override this.

## Head Launcher requirement

The Head Launcher role is a defined position, with a development plan and associated training tasks within Learning Zone. Every launch and recovery must have a designated Head Launcher, subject to the exceptions detailed below.

To act as Head Launcher, the person must hold a **completed** ILB or ALB Head Launcher development plan.

The Head Launcher **must not**:

- Operate in dual roles during launch or recovery operations
- Be part of the operating boat crew
- Be acting in the capacity of Launch Authority.

## Exceptions

- A Head Launcher is not required in the case of boats kept:
  - Afloat alongside
  - Afloat at moorings
  - On a floating dock (Versa/Aquadock), hydraulic lift, or ILB davit.
- Where the method of launching is straight forward and low risk, the Plant Operator may also act as the Head Launcher. Requests for an exception will be considered on a case- by-case basis. Any such exceptions must be endorsed by the Regional Operations Lead and are subject to an LOP and underpinning risk assessment which needs approval from lifeboat services (specialist support).
- Where an ILB is operating from a remote site **and** there is no space for a dedicated Head Launcher to travel in the RNLI vehicle, the Vehicle Driver may act as the Head Launcher. This must be reflected in the station's LOP for the site.

Any launch or recovery involving an ALB carriage or slipway **must** have a dedicated Head Launcher.

**Review information****Next review date**

16/09/2026

**Review frequency**

1 year

**Amendment history**

| Date       | Version | Author/Contributor | Amendment details                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|------------|---------|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 19/04/2024 |         |                    | Content first published on Horizon.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| 19/04/2024 | 1.0     |                    | Content migrated to this new template.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 24/09/2024 | 1.1     | Tim Evans          | Content added.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| 25/11/2024 | 1.2     | Fergus Holley      | Head Launcher requirement incorporated, and document title amended.                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| 10/03/2025 | 1.3     | Alana Ward         | Crewing requirements tables formatted.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 01/04/2025 | 1.4     | Alana Ward         | Crewing requirements updated to reflect changes which took effect from 1/4/2025.                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| 08/04/2025 | 1.5     | Tim Evans          | Head Launcher requirement section updated – Exceptions, second bullet point.                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 16/09/2025 | 1.6     | Conor Curtin       | Current requirements section updated to allow for alternative crewing, with mitigation, on exercise.                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 07/01/2026 | 1.7     | Alana Ward         | The planned requirement for ALBs to be crewed by both a dedicated coxswain and a dedicated mechanic from 1 January 2026 has been paused whilst safe crewing requirements are reviewed.                                                                                                        |
| 20/03/2026 | 1.8     | Pete Murphy        | Bullet point added to Exceptions section: 'Where an ILB is operating from a remote site <b>and</b> there is no space for a dedicated Head Launcher to travel in the RNLI vehicle, the Vehicle Driver may act as the Head Launcher. This must be reflected in the station's LOP for the site'. |